

Where Did Hiram Come From?

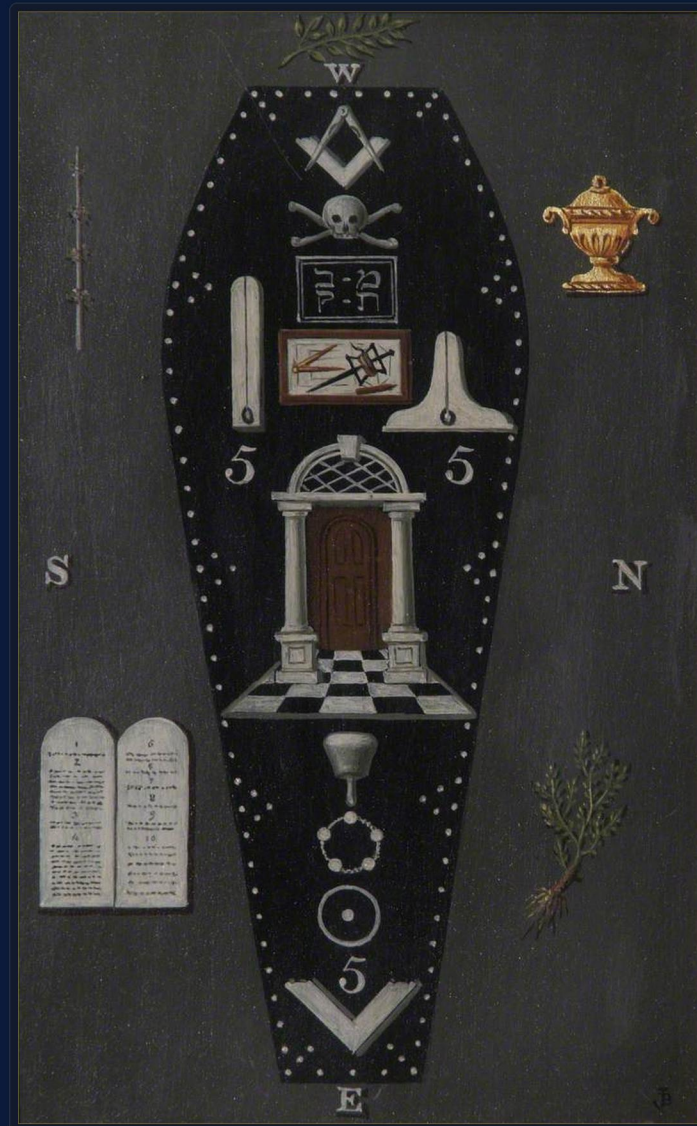
The making of a legend

LORE

The central legend of the Craft is absent from the earliest records and arrives in the 1720s and 30s. What the documents actually show, where the raw material came from, and why a fraternity of builders needed a story about a dead architect.

ON THE TABLE

The Third Degree tracing board



Josiah Bowring (1757-1832) - Third Degree Tracing Board - D2009-41iii - Museum of Freemasonry — Josiah Bowring
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HOW THE PAPER RUNS

0:00	Opening
2:00	Part One: what the old documents actually say
5:30	Part Two: the man in the Bible
8:00	Part Three: the moment it appears
11:00	Part Four: the strangest document of all
14:00	Part Five: so where did it come from?
16:30	Part Six: why they needed it

WHERE DID HIRAM COME FROM?



19:00 Closing

THREE THINGS TO TAKE AWAY

- 1 The legend is in none of the hundred-odd Old Charges, and the murder is not in scripture.
- 2 It appears in print in Prichard's hostile exposure, *Masonry Dissected*, 1730.
- 3 The Graham Manuscript of 1726 — found in 1936 — tells the same shape of story about Noah's grave.

IF YOU ARE ASKED

Is the murder in the Bible?

No. 1 Kings 7 and 2 Chronicles 2 introduce the craftsman and say nothing of his death.

What does "Abif" mean?

An honorific, roughly "his father" — a title of respect for a master craftsman.

When does the legend first appear in print?

Prichard's *Masonry Dissected*, 1730 — a hostile exposure, and a bestseller.

What is the Graham Manuscript?

A masonic document dated 1726, discovered 1936, containing a structurally similar story about the sons of Noah at their father's grave.

Did we always have three degrees?

No. English masonry worked two for most of its early life; the third takes shape in the 1720s.

So is it ancient or invented?

Unresolved, and honest scholarship says so. The evidence supports composition in the 1720s from older materials.

SOURCES

- The Regius Manuscript (c.1390) and Cooke Manuscript (c.1410) — the oldest Old Charges, both published in facsimile
- James Anderson, *The Constitutions of the Free-Masons*, 1723
- Samuel Prichard, *Masonry Dissected*, 1730
- The Graham Manuscript, 1726 — text and commentary in *Ars Quatuor Coronatorum*
- Knoop, Jones & Hamer, *The Early Masonic Catechisms* — the essential collection
- Harry Carr, *The Freemason at Work*
- Douglas Knoop & G. P. Jones, *The Genesis of Freemasonry*

This paper is about the documentary history of the legend — when it appears, in what sources, and what scholars make of it. It is drawn entirely from published masonic scholarship and stays well clear of the work itself.

Every paper is drawn from openly published masonic literature. Nothing here discloses the esoteric work of any degree; all of it is safe to deliver with visitors present, provided the visitors are brethren.

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